Matthew 23:23-24 — Summary

Date: 2026-06-28

Baseline Translation: ESV (English Standard Version)

Original Language: Greek (NA28/Nestle 1904)

Analyst: Peaches (4K Bible Translation Harness)

Passage Context: Seven Woes pericope, culminating indictment (vv23-24) — Jesus returns to the scribes/Pharisees/hypocrites of v1, now naming their specific sin (v23: tithing trifles while omitting the weightier matters of the law), then sharpens the critique into a single proverbial image (v24: blind guides who strain at a gnat and swallow a camel)

Diff Analysis: What Got Lost?

What the Standard Translation Loses

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
1	"scribes" (v23)	The Greek (γραμματεύς) means secretary, registrar, subordinate official — the LSJ marks it as "a term of contempt."	ESV's "scribes" sounds archaic but neutral. The Greek carries contemptuous force — petty clerks, underlings.
2	"Pharisees" (v23)	The Greek (Φαρισαῖος) means "a separatist, i.e. exclusively religious." The word itself encodes separatism.	ESV treats it as a proper noun. The Greek says these are people who have separated into an exclusive sect — separatism is built into the word.
3	"hypocrites" (v23)		

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
		The Greek (ὑροκρίτας) literally means "an actor under an assumed character (stage-player)." The LSJ cites this passage for the metaphorical sense.	The theatrical metaphor — performing a role rather than living a truth — is lost. These aren't just liars; they're ACTORS, stage-players.
4	"tithe" (v23)	The Greek (ἀροδεκατοῦτε) literally means "to take a tenth of" — a precise mathematical term.	Modern readers may miss that this is a LITERAL mathematical operation. You meticulously compute your exact tenth — of spices.
5	"left undone" (v23)	The Greek (ἀφhēvai) means "omitted" — deliberately passed over, not accidentally forgotten.	"Left undone" suggests neglect. "Omitted" suggests a deliberate choice to skip the weightier matters.
6	"weightier" (v23)	The Greek (βαρrèστερα) is COMPARATIVE — "heavier." Not just weighty but heavier THAN the trifles.	The comparative IS the critique: these matters aren't just heavy, they're heavier than what you attend to. The relative weight makes the priority inversion explicit.
7	"judgment" (v23)	The Greek (κρίsis) means "decision; by extension, a tribunal; by implication, JUSTICE (especially, divine law)."	ESV says "judgment" (opinion). The Greek means JUSTICE — and specifically DIVINE LAW. They didn't neglect opinions; they neglected JUSTICE ITSELF.
8	"ought" (v23)	The Greek (ἐ·δει) is a deontic verb — "it is necessary/binding."	Jesus doesn't advise; he binds. They OUGHT to have done these things — a moral obligation, not a suggestion.

#	Standard (ESV)	What's Lost	Why It Matters
9	"blind" (v24)	The Greek (τυφlós) means "opaque, as if smoky" — from the root for smoke. LSJ shows extensive metaphorical use for blindness of mind and judgment.	Not just unable to see but unable to PERCEIVE. Their vision is clouded, smoky — every sense obscured, including judgment.
10	"guides" (v24)	The Greek (ὁηηγός) means "a conductor" — from ὁδos (path) + ηgēomai (to lead) = "one who leads on the path."	Jesus just spent vv8-12 establishing who may lead (Christ alone). Now he calls these people "guides" — blind guides, leading where they cannot see.
11	"strain out" (v24)	The Greek (δiüliso) means "to strain, to filter" — meticulous, obsessive precision.	Not casual attention but FILTERING — the kind of scrutiny that examines every grain.
12	"swallow" (v24)	The Greek (kατapivō) means "to drink down, gulp entire." The LSJ cites this passage as the proverbial example.	Not just eat but CONSUME WHOLE — to take in entirely without examination. The LSJ marks "camel swallow" as a recognized proverb with this verse as its canonical citation.

Concepts Flattened

- **Contemptuous hierarchy**: "Scribes, Pharisees, hypocrites" descends from petty official (contempt) to separatist (ideological) to stage-player (fraud). ESV preserves the three labels but loses the descending force and the specific contempt in each.
- **Mathematical exactitude vs. divine law**: The Pharisees are mathematically exact about trifles (tithe = take a precise tenth) while omitting JUSTICE itself (κpísis =

divine law). The contrast between mathematical precision and moral obliviousness IS the critique.

- **Comparative weight**: "Weightier" is comparative — heavier than the trifles. The relative weight makes the priority inversion explicit. ESV's "weightier" preserves the comparative form but doesn't make the comparison visible.
- **Mental blindness**: "Blind" means opaque, smoky — clouded vision of the mind and all senses, not just the eyes. The Pharisees' blindness is intellectual and moral, not physical.
- **Guide as path-leader**: "Guide" connects to vv8-12 about who may lead. These blind guides presume to lead others on a path they cannot see — a contradiction in terms.
- **The strain/swallow contrast**: Both verbs modify the same blind guides. They strain (filter with obsessive precision) at the gnat (the tiniest thing) AND swallow (gulp down whole) the camel (the enormous thing). The contrast IS the theology: meticulous about small things, oblivious about great ones.
- **The camel proverb**: The LSJ marks "camel swallow" as a recognized classical Greek proverb, with this verse as its canonical citation. Jesus is using a known proverb, not inventing a metaphor.

Expanded Translation (4K)

The recovered "director's cut" — original language nuances restored in readable English. Parenthetical notes explain the nuance recovered.

23 Woe unto you (an exclamation of pain and anger — not just "alas" but the cry of grief itself), scribes (and "scribes" means secretaries, registrars, subordinate officials — a word sometimes used as a term of contempt) and Pharisees (and "Pharisees" means separatists — those who have made themselves exclusively religious, a sect apart), hypocrites (and "hypocrites" literally means stage-players — actors under an assumed character, performing a role rather than living a truth)! For ye tithe (and "tithe" literally means to take a tenth part — a precise mathematical term, not a casual verb) mint and anise and cummin (three specific spices — the trifles you attend to with exacting precision), and have omitted (not merely "left undone" as if by accident, but deliberately passed over) the weightier (and

"weightier" is comparative — not just weighty but heavier, heavier than the trifles you strain at) matters of the law (and "the law" here is the same word used for divine ordinance), judgment (and "judgment" means decision, tribunal, JUSTICE — especially, divine law itself), and mercy, and faith: but these ye ought (and "ought" means it is binding, necessary — not a suggestion but a moral obligation) to have done, and not to have left the other undone (the other — meaning the trifles too; you should have done both, but you have done only the small things and left the great things undone).

24 Ye blind (and "blind" means opaque, as if smoky — clouded vision, not just of the eyes but of the mind and judgment) guides (and "guides" means conductors — literally "ones who lead on the path," from the Greek for "path" and "to lead"; Jesus has just spent verses 8-12 establishing who may lead, and these people are not it), that strain out (and "strain" means to filter, to examine with obsessive precision) the gnat (the tiniest thing — a trifle, a speck), and swallow (and "swallow" means to gulp down whole — to drink entire in one mouthful, to consume completely) the camel (the enormous thing — and the LSJ classical lexicon cites this very passage as the proverbial example: "camel swallow" = this verse)!

Baseline Translation (ESV)

> *23 Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye tithe mint and anise and cummin, and have left undone the weightier matters of the law, justice, and mercy, and faith: but these ye ought to have done, and not to have left the other undone.*
> *24 Ye blind guides, that strain out the gnat, and swallow the camel!*

Individual Verse Analyses

Each verse has its own detailed analysis file with full Greek text, word-by-word analysis, grammatical observations, cultural context, and cross-references:

- Matthew 23:23 — The culminating indictment: scribes (contempt), Pharisees (separatists), hypocrites (stage-players) who tithe trifles with mathematical precision while omitting JUSTICE itself — the weightier matters of the divine law
- Matthew 23:24 — The proverbial image: blind (opaque, smoky, clouded in mind not just eyes) guides (path-leaders, connecting to vv8-12) who strain at a gnat (obsessive precision about tiny things) and swallow a camel (oblivious consumption of enormous things) — a recognized classical Greek proverb

Theological Insights Recovered

1. **The descending hierarchy of contempt (v23)**: Jesus names them as scribes (petty officials, clerks — a term of contempt), then Pharisees (separatists — those who made themselves exclusively religious), then hypocrites (stage-players — actors performing a character). The hierarchy descends from professional insignificance to ideological separatism to outright fraud. The same people are all three: petty clerks who became a sect who became actors playing a part.

2. **Mathematical exactitude vs. divine law (v23)**: The Pharisees TITHE — they take a precise mathematical tenth — of spices. Meanwhile they omit JUDGMENT — which means JUSTICE, specifically DIVINE LAW. The contrast between mathematical precision about trifles and moral obliviousness about justice IS the critique. They can compute a tenth but cannot see justice.

3. **"Judgment" = justice and divine law (v23)**: The Greek κρίσις doesn't mean "judgment" as opinion. It means JUSTICE — and the Strong's definition explicitly says "especially, divine law." When Jesus says they've left undone "judgment," he means they've left undone JUSTICE ITSELF. The ESV's "judgment" sounds like they neglected to form opinions. The Greek says they neglected JUSTICE. The cross-

reference to Micah 6:8 ("do justly, and love mercy, and walk humbly with thy God") confirms the triad: judgment = do justly, mercy = love mercy, faith = walk humbly with thy God.

4. **"Blind" as mental, not just physical (v24)**: The Greek τυφλός means "opaque, as if smoky" — from the root for smoke. The LSJ shows it used metaphorically for blindness of ALL the senses and the mind. Jesus isn't saying these people can't see with their eyes. He's saying they can't perceive at all — their judgment is clouded, smoky, every sense obscured. They are blind in their MINDS.

5. **"Blind guides" as contradiction and connection (v24)**: A guide who is blind is a contradiction — one who leads others on a path they cannot see. The Greek ὁδηγός derives from ὁδος (path) + ηgēomai (to lead) — literally "one who leads on the path." Jesus just spent vv8-12 establishing who may lead (Christ alone is instructor). These blind guides presume to lead where they cannot see — connecting v24 directly to the instructor prohibition of v10.

6. **The strain/swallow contrast IS the theology (v24)**: The two participles — straining and swallowing — both modify the same blind guides. They STRAIN at the gnat (filter with obsessive precision, examining every grain of the tiniest thing) and SWALLOW the camel (gulp down the enormous thing whole, without examination). The contrast encodes the priority inversion of v23 in visual form: meticulous about small things, oblivious about great ones. That IS their blindness — not that they can't see, but that they choose to see only the small things.

7. **The camel proverb (v24)**: The LSJ classical lexicon cites this passage as the proverbial example: "prov. kaēmēlon kaτapivēn Ev.Matt.23.24." The expression "to swallow the camel" was a recognized proverb in classical Greek. Jesus is using a known image, not inventing a new metaphor — the Pharisees' sin is a recognized pattern so common it earned a proverb.

Notes for Further Study

- **Hebrew/OT analysis**: The three weightier matters (judgment, mercy, faith) echo Micah 6:8's "do justly, love mercy, walk humbly with thy God." A full Hebrew analysis of Micah 6:8 could reveal whether the Hebrew carries additional nuance that Jesus's Greek transfers — or doesn't.
- **Verse numbering discrepancy**: The LSJ cites Ev.Matt.23.13 for ὑpokpítas (hypocrite), but the actual verse is 23:23. This is a known bible-api Greek source issue (vv13-14 are swapped with vv23-24 in some datasets). Needs verification against the Nestle 1904 manuscript directly.
- **The three spices**: ἥδyosmov (mint), ἄvēthov (anise/dill), and κēmivov (cummin/cumin) are all classified as plant>spice_incense in bible-db. A deeper study could examine whether these three specific spices had cultural significance in Jesus's time beyond their triviality — were they the smallest known spices, or associated with particular religious practices?
- **The camel's Hebrew origin**: Both Φapisaios (Pharisee) and kaēmēlos (camel) have Hebrew origins. The LSJ notes kaēmēlos is "Semitic word, cf. Hebr. gāmāl." Is there a connection between the Pharisees (Hebrew-origin word for separatist) and the camel (Hebrew-origin word) they swallow? This may be coincidental but warrants investigation.
- **"Ought" and the deontic tradition**: The deontic verb ἔδei (ought, it is binding) appears throughout Matthew's discourse. A cross-passage study of Jesus's use of deontic language could reveal the pattern of his moral authority — where he advises, where he binds, and where he prohibits.
- **Retroactive v3 conversion**: This passage follows the v3 granular format. Older passages (Matthew 5:3-12, 22:41-45, 23:1-7) still need conversion to this format with Strong's numbers and etymology data.

Analysis completed by: Peaches (4K Bible Translation Harness)

Review status: Pending review

Formats: Markdown (.md) • HTML (.html) • PDF (.pdf) — to be generated